

NITISH KUMAR

Heartland Hero



**NITISH AND HIS SUPPORTERS
FLASH THE V-SIGN AFTER
THEIR VICTORY**

KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN

General Elections 2009 marked the first time in 20 years when Nitish Kumar did not himself contest the polls. That was immaterial, however, as Nitish was the tidal wave that swept away all in sight in a bitterly fought personality-based election in Bihar, pounding the Lalu Prasad Yadav-Ram Vilas Paswan combine and the Congress into political insignificance in Bihar. But how did he do it? By blending caste politics with development and getting his basics right. He knew exactly who his political adversaries were and had his plans in place for both Paswan and Lalu. Months before the elections, Nitish gave a decisive twist to Dalit politics by announcing a string of welfare measures for the neglected sub-castes among Dalits, effectively forcing self-styled Dalit champion Paswan to give up his Hajipur seat to JD(U)'s Ram Sundar Das. Nitish's decision to induct Lalu's *bête noire* Ranjan Yadav and Das into the JD(U) just before the polls kept both RJD and LJP bosses on tenterhooks.

Lalu-Paswan's over-reliance on past statistics—that they had together walked away with over 45 per cent of

the vote during the 2004 elections—also put paid to their chances. “Their arithmetic failed them,” Nitish said. Indeed, seeking an advantage in caste polarisation became a huge disadvantage for both Lalu and Paswan, who wasted precious campaign time trying to resurrect a caste alliance. Paswan also blames the division of secular votes as the Congress fought separately. Although Nitish called the election result a positive vote and an endorsement of his formula of good governance with justice, he also owes his success to his invocation of fear, reminding voters of the jungle raj of the RJD. The much improved law and order situation clearly separates his regime from his predecessors’. And Bihar residents, who have experienced the advantages of less crime, went beyond caste considerations to vote for Nitish. He also succeeded in creating fissures in Lalu's Muslim vote bank through his pro-minority stance and welfare measures.

by Amitabh Srivastava

MAMATA BANERJEE

Turn of the Tigress

As the winning trend started trickling in on Saturday, she relaxed, shifted from her treadmill to the music system and put on her favourite Tagore songs. For close to 25 years, Mamata Banerjee has never been so happy, except once in 1984 when the Congress won 16 out of the 42 Lok Sabha seats in West Bengal. But this time, after taking the Congress-Trinamool alliance to a decisive victory, she came out from her bedroom shortly after 2.30 p.m., called her sisters-in-law, her ageing mother and flashed a V sign. She even instructed her workers not to behave in an improper manner asking them to “go home and rest”. The 54-year-old seems to have done the unimaginable—winning the numbers game against the Left Front.

But what ensured this upset for the Left? For, this was not an anti-incumbency mandate alone; that factor could have ruled on earlier occasions in 32 years. What is convincing is that, while the Congress led from the front at the national level, in Bengal it has had to latch on to the coat-tails of the Trinamool, making Mamata the undisputed opposition leader in the state. Even before the elections, she had said, “The Congress needs me and not the other way round,” and got her way with Pranab Mukherjee on seat preferences. Congress leaders now say, “Thank God, there is no need for Left support at the Centre”.

The Left Front too helped Mamata in her efforts. That the party has been banished in and around the city, with even Dinesh Trivedi winning in Barrackpore—supposedly one of the biggest Left strongholds just outside

SINGUR, NANDIGRAM AND THE PERCEPTION THAT THE LEFT FRONT GOVERNMENT WAS OUT TO GRAB LAND FROM THE POOR VOTED THE LEFT OUT FROM ITS THREE-DECADE-OLD BASTION.